

COACH GUIDE

Who are we?

SCIENTIFIC BASIS

- Cameron & Quinn (2011): teams that consciously name their culture perform more stably under pressure than teams that do not
- Baumeister & Leary (1995): social belonging is a basic need. Culture agreements strengthen that belonging at the team level
- Tod et al. (2011): public commitment, such as signing, increases adherence to behavioral agreements by 30-40%
- Carron & Eys (2012): shared identity is the strongest predictor of team cohesion and performance motivation across a full season

OBJECTIVE

Players name what binds them as a team. They formulate culture anchors and record their personal promise. This is the foundation for all the collaboration that follows.

COACH TIP

Go first: share your own three words for the team before asking the players. This normalizes vulnerability and significantly raises the quality of their answers.

WATCH OUT FOR

Do not let the group discussion on culture anchors become a complaint session about last season. Actively redirect if the tone gets too negative. The focus is looking ahead.

EXERCISES, ONE BY ONE

Everything per exercise, in order

1 Three words for our team

⌚ 10 min

PURPOSE	Players make explicit what culture means to them concretely. By starting individually before sharing, you avoid groupthink. Everyone hears their own voice first.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"You have two minutes to write alone. No talking. Write down three words you want people to say about our team. Not about standings, but about our behavior and character. There is no right or wrong answer."</i>
EXAMPLE	Three players write "honesty", "fight", "fun". Ask: "When did we show this last year?" and "When did we not?" This makes the words tangible instead of abstract. Then combine the most chosen words into three team words.

2 Culture anchors

⌚ 12 min

PURPOSE	Teams that consciously name what they want to keep and let go bring positive behavior back faster and break less easily with old behavior that did not serve them. This makes change concrete.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"Think about last season. Left side: write what we want to keep as a team, behaviors, habits, moments. Right side: what do we consciously leave behind? What did not fit who we want to be? Two minutes writing, then a short discussion."</i>
EXAMPLE	A team writes "keep: we stand up for each other after a mistake", "let go: grumbling on the bench when you do not play." Discuss as a group: "How do we make sure we let this go? What is our concrete agreement?" Keep it in behavior, not vague intention.

3 Sign the team contract

⌚ 8 min

PURPOSE	Public commitment through signing increases the chance that players actually keep their behavioral agreements. A contract players wrote themselves works stronger than rules handed down from above. The signature makes it serious.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"Write down three concrete promises you make to the team this season. Not vague, but measurable: something you can check yourself. Then sign with name and date."</i>
EXAMPLE	Instead of "I promise to be a better teammate," help the player toward something concrete: "I promise to be the first to encourage a teammate after a mistake" or "I promise to always be on time, even for informal practices." Ask two players to read their promise out loud after writing.

COACHING IN DEPTH

How to help your team further

HOW TO SUPPORT YOUR TEAM

1. Build the group discussion in two steps: first individual writing (2 min), then sharing. This way everyone hears their own voice before the group's, and you avoid one voice determining the rest.
2. Use the chosen culture words actively for the rest of the season. "This is exactly what perseverance means" makes culture tangible in the moment. Name it concretely when you see it.
3. Explicitly name the difference between a culture anchor and a match goal. Players sometimes confuse these. Culture anchors are about behavior, not titles or scores.
4. When signing, check if promises are concrete enough. If you cannot check a promise three months from now, it is too vague. Help the player make it more specific.
5. Leave at least 5 minutes after signing for a calm landing. A moment of quiet before moving on. This lets the meaning settle.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Which word did almost everyone choose, and what does that say about who you already are as a team?
2. What is personally hardest for you to let go of this season, and why?
3. Which promise do you dare to say out loud in front of the whole team?
4. When was there a moment last season where your culture really clicked? What made that moment different?
5. How do you make sure this contract is not forgotten after today?

FOLLOW-UP IN THE COMING WEEKS

1. Collect the signed contracts and take a photo. Bring them back midseason at an explicit check-in: "what did you promise, and how is it going?"
2. Display the three culture words visibly in the locker room or put them in the team app. Actively refer to them at evaluation moments.
3. In the week after the session, name at least twice concrete behavior you observe that fits the culture anchors. "This is exactly what we meant."
4. Plan a check-in after six weeks: have players reread their own promise and score from 1 to 10 how well they have kept it so far.

COMMON PITFALLS

- Starting the group discussion too quickly before everyone has thought individually. Groupthink then takes over the individual voice, and you lose the honesty you need.
- Discussing culture anchors as a complaint session about last season instead of a forward look at who you want to be. Redirect if the tone gets too negative.
- Accepting promises that are too vague. "I promise to work harder" is not measurable and will fade. Help every player toward one concrete, visible promise.
- Forgetting to follow up on the signed contract. A contract without follow-up is decoration, not an agreement. Plan the follow-up now.

COACH GUIDE

How do we work?

SCIENTIFIC BASIS

- Edmondson (1999): psychological safety, the feeling that you can make mistakes, is the strongest predictor of team performance in uncertain environments
- Eys et al. (2015): the "I see, I feel, I ask" model significantly reduces aggressive language and raises the chance of a constructive conversation
- Walsh et al. (2020): rituals in sports teams increase group cohesion and reduce performance anxiety in players, including young athletes
- Lencioni (2002): avoidance of conflict is the second dysfunction of teams. Healthy conflict is a sign of trust, not weakness

OBJECTIVE

Players learn how safe they feel, practice a concrete accountability tool, and translate culture into daily rituals. This closes the short track with action.

COACH TIP

Model the "I see, I feel, I ask" exercise yourself first. Give a fictional but recognizable example in front of the whole group before letting players start. This way they know exactly what format you expect.

WATCH OUT FOR

The trust barometer can be sensitive if the team has just been through a difficult period. Be ready to listen. Point out that there is no "right" score and that no one has to show their scores.

EXERCISES, ONE BY ONE

Everything per exercise, in order

1 Trust barometer

⌚ 10 min

PURPOSE	Players make explicit how safe they feel in four concrete situations. This makes an invisible group dynamic visible and gives language to something that would otherwise go unspoken. It is a diagnosis, not a judgment.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"Give an honest score from 1 to 10 for each situation. No right or wrong. No one has to show their scores if they do not want to. Take two minutes to write. Then you can briefly explain if you want, but you do not have to."</i>
EXAMPLE	If most players score a 4 or lower on "I dare to admit mistakes," say: "What would need to change for you to score a 6 tomorrow?" This shifts from diagnosis to action. Look for the first small step, not the perfect solution.

2 The difficult conversation

⌚ 12 min

PURPOSE	Players practice a concrete communication model that separates observation, feeling, and request from attack and accusation. This way they dare to have difficult conversations without them escalating into conflict.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"Model this yourself first with a fictional example. Then write: I SEE (what you concretely observe, without interpretation), I FEEL (what it does to you, without accusation), I ASK YOU TO (one concrete, doable action). No names needed on paper."</i>
EXAMPLE	Wrong: "You are always late." Right: I SEE: "you have been 10 minutes late to practice the last few weeks." I FEEL: "that makes me uncertain about our agreements as a team." I ASK YOU TO: "be on time, or let me know in advance if you cannot." Read this out loud to the whole group before they start writing.

3 Rituals and culture promise

⌚ 10 min

PURPOSE	Culture without rituals fades. Small, repeated actions keep culture alive, even when pressure rises. The signature symbolically and powerfully closes the short track.
SAY TO PLAYERS	<i>"Write three rituals: one before training, one after a game, one in a difficult moment. Then write one sentence that says what you contribute to the culture of this team. Sign with name and date."</i>
EXAMPLE	Rituals can be tiny: "before every practice we name one person who did something well that week." That takes 30 seconds and creates connection. Discuss as a group which ritual would have the most impact and pick one to start next week.

COACHING IN DEPTH

How to help your team further

HOW TO SUPPORT YOUR TEAM

1. Start the trust barometer with a calibration: "if 10 means you dare to share everything, what is a 5 for your team?" This gives scores more meaning and makes them comparable.
2. Model the "I see, I feel, I ask" exercise yourself with a fictional example. Use a situation that is recognizable but does not directly target anyone. Then players dare to practice too.
3. For rituals: do not ask which ritual sounds best, but which ritual is easiest to keep up for at least 8 weeks. Small and doable lands, ambitious and complicated does not.
4. Close the session with a circle: each player says in one sentence what they take away. No discussion afterward, just listening. This anchors the session individually.
5. Follow up on rituals actively for the first four weeks. Name them when you see them: "this is exactly the ritual you chose." Rituals that are not supported disappear within two weeks.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS TO ASK

1. Which of the four trust questions felt most dangerous to answer honestly, and why?
2. Have you ever addressed someone about their behavior? What worked and what did not?
3. Which ritual would immediately change our team, even if it only takes 30 seconds each time?
4. When did the atmosphere in this team feel best? What made that moment different?
5. What do you want a new teammate to say about this group five years from now?

FOLLOW-UP IN THE COMING WEEKS

1. Introduce the first ritual at the very next practice. Explicitly name that it comes from the players themselves, not from you as coach. Ownership belongs to the team.
2. Check the ritual agreements after four weeks: are they still active? If not, what held them back? Discuss this briefly and openly, without judgment.
3. Use the "I see, I feel, I ask" model yourself when you have a difficult conversation with a player. This models it outside the session and makes it normal.
4. Plan a short look-back on the short track after six weeks: what changed? What did not happen? Plan now when you will do this.

COMMON PITFALLS

- Using the trust barometer as a diagnostic tool to judge the team, instead of as a starting point for a conversation about what can be better.
- Skipping the "I see, I feel, I ask" exercise because "they already know this." Knowing is not the same as being able to apply it under pressure. Always practice it.
- Introducing rituals that are too complex or time-consuming. A ritual that players experience as a burden disappears within two weeks. Small and consistent works.
- Closing the track without a concrete next step or date for a check-in. Without follow-up, everything you built today will fade. Plan it now.